

G A M FOR SOME MODIFICATION?

Sick of playing the same titles on your hard drive over and again? How about producing your own offering just to show you can do better?

In the early days, gamers would almost stumble onto programming while playing their favourite game. Early computer games were written in BASIC, and the player could quite easily break into the source code and read what the programmer had written. These gamers very often grew up to become programmers!

But that was then. Game development is like rocket science now. The technology curve of modern 3D games is as advanced as F1 racing (gouraud shading, doppler effects, anti-aliasing anyone?). It's almost impossible to build a game from scratch. With 3D engines and gazillion lines of coding required for a game, game development is an impossible proposition for someone without a mathematics or physics degree.

The time, money and resources required to make a title today are daunting. You need a team of artists, programmers and designers. Hence, before you attempt to make a whole new game, it makes more sense to take baby steps and try to modify an existing game.

Mods 101

Modifications or mods have their roots in hacking and reverse engineering game code, but now they've evolved to a point where mod support in games is almost a requirement. Any game released these days without a large editing component is frowned upon by reviewers. Games like *Quake* and *Half-Life* were almost designed to serve as an SDK (Software Development Kit) for the community to build on.

A mod is essentially a new game you can play, using modified rules, weapons or levels. Since the early days of *Quake I*, id Software has generously allowed the community to create their own mods. It's these mods that have given *Quake* its longevity and fostered the great *Quake* community we have today. *Capture the Flag* and *Team Fortress* turned out to be the driving points for the game

ILLUSTRATION: Ram